

The \$4.99 playbook.

Three ideation agents generated candidates; a behavioral-science gatekeeper researched each against the actual literature (effect sizes, replication records, tipping-backlash studies) and attached the guardrails the evidence demands. Ten survived. Then a designer, an engineer, and a pricing scientist spec'd the tier. Standing rules: 0% of tips forever, the core request-tip-queue loop stays free, nothing a fan would resent on reading exactly how it works.

1. Room-Tuned Presets — Tip chips that anchor to what tonight's room is actually giving.

Pro performers' pages swap the fixed \$2/\$5/\$10 chips for presets computed from the night's rolling median tip, with the middle chip pre-highlighted slightly above that median (room median \$4 -> chips \$3/\$5/\$8, \$5 preselected). All amounts stay visible and editable, custom amount always available; free tier keeps static chips. Pure client-side math over the Supabase tips table, no new infra.

- Regression discontinuity on 13M+ NYC taxi rides: the suggested tip menu causally shifts tips; the higher default menu raised average tips roughly 10%, but also increased the share of riders leaving no tip — anchors raise amounts while taxing frequency at the margin.

Haggag & Paci, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 2014

- Meta-analysis of 58 default studies (N=73,675): pooled effect $d=0.68$ (95% CI 0.53-0.83), roughly 2-3x larger than social-norm or framing nudges; defaults are among the most robustly replicated choice-architecture effects, though several studies found null and two found negative effects.

Jachimowicz, Duncan, Weber & Johnson, Behavioural Public Policy, 2019

Expected impact: Expected +8-12% in average tip size on nights when the room median sits above the static anchors, per the taxi RD (~10% from a higher suggested menu) and the social-information field experiment (~12% from anchoring on others' real gifts); on a \$50-150 tip night that is roughly \$5-15 extra per gig, so one gig plausibly covers 1-3 months of the \$4.99 subscription — an easy Pro sell. Expect a small offsetting rise in no · Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low if built with the guardrails, moderate if built as pitched. What saves it: the anchor is a true statement about the room (descriptive norm), every amount is visible and editable, custom entry survives, and the fan initiates the flow — so a fan reading exactly how it works sees 'the app suggests what people here are actually tipping,' which is defensible and arguably more ho

UI: Tip sheet (fan checkout chip row); on/off toggle lives on the performer dashboard Pro panel — Same three-pill chip row on the always-ink #0B0F12 tip sheet (money surfaces never take the fan-page theme skin — trust reads neutral), Manrope ExtraBold amounts in gold. The middle chip is pre-highlighted with a 2px teal ring and a slight size bump — highlight Copy: "Dashboard toggle: "Auto-tune my tip chips to tonight's room — never below my defaults.""

2. Bump Meter — A live progress bar showing exactly how few dollars stand between a song and the top of the queue.

Every queued song shows its gap to the song above it ('\$3 more bumps you to #1'), updating in realtime via Supabase subscriptions. When a fan's song is within one preset chip of overtaking, their page pulses the exact chip that closes the gap. Free tier keeps the plain queue; Pro unlocks the gap display.

- Café reward-card field study: customers accelerated purchases as they approached the free-coffee goal (inter-purchase times shortened ~20%, ~0.7 days faster near goal); parallel acceleration found on an online song-rating site (more visits, more ratings, fewer session terminations near threshold); post-reward reset followed by renewed acceleration, i.e., a retention pattern

Kivetz, Urminsky & Zheng, Journal of Marketing Research 43(1), 2006

- Goal gradient in helping behavior: monetary contributions to others' goals accelerate near goal completion — Internet field study of Kiva micro-lending plus a large-scale field experiment showed funds close to their goal received more donations than distant ones; mediation analyses showed the driver is heightened perceived impact of the late-stage dollar

Cryder, Loewenstein & Seltman, Journal of Experimental Social Psychology 49(6), 2013

Expected impact: Primary effect is tip frequency, not tip size: converting one-and-done tippers into second and third same-night tips. Field analogs support ~15-25% acceleration in paid actions near a visible goal (Kivetz et al. 2006: ~20% purchase acceleration; Cryder et al. 2013: significantly higher contribution rates near goal), and competitive-arousal dynamics add occasional escalation bursts in rival-group settings (bachelorette · Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low-to-moderate, and manageable — but not zero. The display itself is honest: the gap is the true live dollar difference, the chip amounts are real, 100% goes to the performer, and the paid bump visibly happens

UI: Fan page queue (every queued song row; the fan's own request card is elevated) + a one-time chip pulse on the tip sheet — Each queue row carries a compact '+\$3 to pass' affordance; the fan's own song card is elevated with a 3px progress track in the performer's theme accent, gap dollars right-aligned in gold, destination rank in Manrope Bold. The track fills live over the existin Copy: "On the fan's song card: "\$3 more bumps 'Valerie' to #1.""

3. Hype Ticker — A live feed of who just tipped what, turning every tip into public social proof.

Opt-in first-name ticker on the fan page and a big-screen/projector view: 'Maddie bumped Valerie \$5.' Amounts are shown; fans choose anonymity at checkout. Pro toggle on the performer dashboard; renders from the same realtime tips channel the queue already uses.

- Quoting a prior donor's high gift (90th-95th percentile) raised new-donor contributions ~12% (\$13) in a public-radio field experiment; effect concentrated in NEW donors — matching first-time fans at a gig — and did not crowd out later giving

Shang & Croson, The Economic Journal, 2009

- Field experiment: telling people many others contribute raises contribution rates (conditional cooperation); effect is real but small and works on marginal/indifferent givers, not never-givers

Frey & Meier, American Economic Review, 2004

Expected impact: Expected lift of roughly 5-15% in tip revenue per gig when display design emphasizes top recent tips, via two channels the literature separates: frequency (descriptive norm 'people here tip' converts first-time/marginal tippers — the Shang & Croson new-donor effect and Frey & Meier's marginal-giver effect map exactly onto open-mic crowds where QR tipping is novel) and amount (visible high tips anchor up; Twitch contains Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low-to-moderate, and manageable. No deception: the ticker reports real, consented events, and a fan reading exactly how it works sees a recognition feature, not a trick — the Twitch evidence even suggests tippers WANT the visibility (anonymous gifts don't inspire others; named ones do)

UI: Fan page (single-line ribbon under the header) + big-screen/projector view; the name opt-in is an unchecked checkbox on the tip sheet — A one-line marquee ribbon skinned by the performer's theme: first name in the theme accent, amount in gold, song title in italic Manrope, entries sliding left on a gentle loop. The big-screen view is an ink #0B0F12 lower-third with 8-second dwell cards; tips a Copy: "Ticker line: "Maddie just bumped 'Valerie' — \$5" / checkout opt-in: "Put my name on the ticker.""

4. Tonight's Fund — The performer names one concrete thing tonight's tips buy — with a live thermometer.

Pro performer sets a truthful goal card before the set ('New tuner pedal — \$120') with a photo and a progress bar on the fan page; hitting 100% triggers a room-wide celebration and a shoutout-wall entry. One Supabase column plus a progress bar; money flow untouched.

- Meta-analysis of 41 identifiable-victim-effect studies finds an overall effect of only $r = .05$ — significant but negligible; the headline IVE claim is far weaker than textbook treatments imply.

Lee & Feeley, Social Influence, 2016

- High-powered direct replication ($N > 1,000$) of Small, Loewenstein & Slovic (2007) found no effect of victim identifiability on donations ($\eta^2 \approx .000$, 95% CI [.000, .003]) and robust Bayesian meta-analysis indicated strong publication bias and evidence for the null ($BF_{01} = 14.93$). The feature's named citation basis does not replicate.

Maier et al., Collabra: Psychology (UC Press), 2023

Expected impact: Modest but real expected lift, concentrated in the last stretch of the goal. The strongest quantified analogue (overhead-free assurance, $\sim 2.5\times$ donation-rate lift in direct mail) will not transfer at that magnitude to a live room where social motives already operate, but the direction is well-supported by three independent field literatures: concrete-use framing increases real giving, contribution rates rise as small · Build: ~ 2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low, with two specific failure modes to guard. (1) Fungibility gap: tips are not escrowed, so if the card reads as 'your \$5 literally buys the pedal' a literal-minded fan (Tony) could feel misled when he realizes money just goes to the performer's Stripe account

UI: Fan page (pinned card above the queue); 60-second setup card on the performer dashboard before the set — Pinned card at the top of the themed fan page: the performer's own photo of the actual item, goal title in Manrope Bold, raised-of-total in gold over a teal thermometer with a soft glow at the leading edge. Beneath the bar, a fixed small-caps trust line — the Copy: ""New tuner pedal — \$84 of \$120. LiveQue takes 0%: every dollar goes straight to Mars.""

5. Encore Tap — One-tap re-tipping for the rest of the night after the first tip.

After a fan's first tip, a Stripe SetupIntent saves their payment method for the session (Stripe holds it; LiveQue still never touches funds), and a persistent 'Tip \$5 again' button repeats the last amount without reopening the payment sheet. Session-scoped, clearly labeled, cancel anytime.

- One-click buying adoption raised customer spending by ~28.5% on average over 35 months of quasi-experimental data from an online retailer, driven by more frequent orders and wider assortment rather than bigger baskets; effect concentrated among moderate spenders. Single-firm data; authors explicitly call for replication across industries.

Unal & Park, 'Fewer Clicks, More Purchases,' Management Science 69(12), 2023

- Meta-analysis of 392 effect sizes from 71 papers: overall cashless effect is small but significant ($g=0.135$, CI [0.068, 0.203]); decoupled vs. coupled payments is NOT a significant moderator ($b=-0.024$, $p=.568$); the effect is essentially null in pro-social consumption situations including tips and donations (predicted $g=0.023$ vs 0.253 non-pro-social; $b=-0.230$, $p<.001$); and the effect has weakened over time ($b=-0.006$, $p=.025$). This directly undercuts the candidate's claimed 'payment decoupling sharply increases spend' mechanism for a tipping context.

Schomburgk, Belli & Hoffmann, 'Less cash, more splash? A meta-analysis on the cashless effect,' Journal of Retailing 100, 2024

Expected impact: Honest expectation: a tip-FREQUENCY lever among fans who have already tipped once, not a windfall. Do not promise the 28.5% from Unal & Park — that is one e-commerce retailer, and the meta-analytic record says pain-of-paying effects are near-zero in pro-social contexts, so the gain here comes purely from removed steps at a high-arousal moment (song just played, round of drinks, bachelorette rivalry). A defensible plan. Build: ~3 weeks.

Guardrail: Low, with two real edges to guard. What keeps it clean: the button repeats the fan's OWN last amount (self-anchored — it sidesteps the preset-anchor and guilt-prompt dynamics that drive the documented tipping backlash), it is session-scoped, plainly labeled, cancelable, and stored-credential one-tap is a pattern fans already trust from Amazon/Apple Pay; it survives a fan readin

UI: Tip sheet (post-payment opt-in on the receipt) + a persistent docked button on the fan page for the rest of the set — After the first successful tip, the ink receipt sheet offers an unchecked toggle: save-my-card-for-tonight, with the Stripe clarification inline because the trust moat is the product. Once on, a pill button docks bottom-right of the fan page floating above the Copy: ""Tip \$5 again — one tap. Tonight only; Stripe holds your card, LiveQue never sees it.""

6. Make It Even — A round-up nudge that lets fans land on a satisfying round total.

When a custom amount or add-ons produce a non-round total, checkout shows an optional one-tap 'make it an even \$10,' with the difference going to the performer like any tip. The exact final number is always displayed before pay; declining is one tap.

- Field data across three payment domains shows strong revealed preference for round totals: 56% of self-pumped gasoline purchases ended in .00 (plus 7% at .01 — failed attempts to stop on the dollar), ~73% of tips were round whole-dollar amounts (another 8% half-dollar), and pay-what-you-want payments clustered at round numbers well above chance. Establishes the preference exists in tipping itself, not just retail pricing.

Lynn, Flynn & Helion, Journal of Economic Psychology, 2013

- The exact round-up mechanic tested experimentally: round-up requests accepted 63-76% vs 39% for a flat \$1 ask (lab); in a 19-day field experiment at a zoo cafeteria, round-up participation was 45% vs 18% for flat requests, raising donation revenue per transaction by 21%. Mechanism: round-up framing reduces the perceived pain of paying even at identical amounts (61.8% vs 31.3% for an identical \$0.50).

Kelting, Robinson & Lutz, Journal of Consumer Psychology, 2019

Expected impact: Modest but real and provable. Honest transfer of effect sizes: the zoo's +21%/transaction does not carry over (there the round-up WAS the donation; here it is incremental on an existing tip). The realistic delta is the gap to the round total — typically \$0.30-\$1.65 — on the subset of transactions with non-round totals (custom amounts and add-on stacks like drink mode; the preset \$2/\$5/\$10 buttons are already round, s · Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low, and lower than almost any other upsell mechanic, but not zero. The resentment literature on checkout charity and tip-creep identifies three poisons: not knowing where the money goes, being watched while deciding, and being nagged

UI: Tip sheet only, between the running total and the pay button, and only when the total lands off-round — A single ghost-button line: 1px teal outline, no fill, never preselected — 'Make it an even \$10' in Manrope Medium with the delta in small gold type. One tap adds the difference to the performer like any tip; ignoring it costs nothing, and it never re-asks aft Copy: ""Make it an even \$10? (+\$1.50 to Mars)""

7. Marquee Request — A visible top-shelf option — headline the set — that makes a \$10 tip feel moderate.

Pro adds one premium line above the chips: 'Headline the set — \$25: guaranteed next slot + your name on the marquee banner all night.' It is a real, always-fulfilled product (queue pin + banner render), not a decoy in the deceptive sense — just an expensive real option.

- Large personalized field experiment on donation appeal scales: the leftmost (lowest) anchor drives likelihood of giving (lower anchor = more donors), while steepening the scale upward increases average donation magnitude; both effects stronger for infrequent donors. Direct blueprint for adding a high top option while keeping the \$2 chip first.

De Bruyn & Prokopec, 'Opening a donor's wallet: The influence of appeal scales on likelihood and magnitude of donation,' Journal of Consumer Psychology, 2013

- 13 million NYC taxi rides: higher default tip suggestions raised tip amounts on the order of 10%, but excessively high suggestions increased the share of riders leaving zero tip — replicated backlash threshold that dictates keeping the marquee line visually quiet and the low chips primary.

Haggag & Paci, 'Default Tips,' American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, 2014

Expected impact: Two additive channels. Channel 1, the anchor lift: field evidence (Haggag & Paci ~10% tip-amount lift from higher visible suggestions; De Bruyn & Prokopec magnitude gains from steeper scales; Pinger et al. ~5 percentage-point share shift toward the new middle) supports a single-digit-to-~10% lift in average tip size, concentrated in group crowds — for a performer clearing \$50/night in tips across 8 gigs/month, that is ~\$5. Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low-to-moderate, and it passes the read-the-mechanism-aloud test: 'the \$25 option is real, always fulfilled, and also makes \$10 feel moderate' is ordinary good-better-best menu design, the same structure as a wine list — a fan told exactly this has learned nothing hidden. The guilt-tipping backlash literature targets coercive preset prompts at forced point-of-payment; LiveQue's

UI: Fan page, one quiet row below the chip group; fulfillment renders on the big-screen marquee strip and fan-page header — Deliberately smaller than the chips so the low anchors stay primary (the backlash-threshold constraint): a hairline gold rule, a small star glyph, 'Headline the set' in Manrope SemiBold, \$25 in gold, and a teal 'guaranteed next' tag. Tapping expands a detail c Copy: ""Headline the set — \$25: guaranteed next slot + your name on the marquee all night.""

8. Star Rush Hour — Performer-triggered windows where tips earn double Stars toward the Top Fans board.

From the stage view, the performer taps 'Star Rush'; for 15 minutes tips earn 2x Stars chips toward Top Fans Tonight (leaderboard points only — dollar amounts and queue effects unchanged, and the banner says so). Countdown banner on all fan pages via the existing realtime channel.

- Original medium-maximization studies: adding a worthless points medium altered choices and increased willingness to exert effort even when the points-to-outcome mapping made the option no better; multiple lab experiments, replicated internally across marketing-relevant contexts. No failed direct replications found, but evidence is laboratory choice/effort tasks, not field payment data — supporting mechanism only.

Hsee, Yu, Zhang & Zhang, Journal of Consumer Research, 2003; corroborated by van Osselaer et al. on myopic maximization of intrinsically worthless loyalty points; boundary conditions extended by Erev et al., Journal of Behavioral Decision Making, 2019

- Points-pressure effect in the field: a supermarket frequency-reward program produced a ~6% storewide sales lift during the 8-week program window as customers accelerated purchases to earn points, plus +17.5% weekly spend among redeemers post-reward; before/after field design, ~400% ROI. Confirmed longitudinally by Liu (2007, Journal of Marketing): light users increased purchase frequency under a real points program.

Taylor & Neslin, Journal of Retailing, 2005; Liu, Journal of Marketing, 2007

Expected impact: Modest but real, concentrated where leaderboard rivalry is already live. Mechanism: converts set lulls into tip occasions for status-competitive fans (Kayla's bachelorette group forcing the bride's song, Tony defending a top spot, Maddie when \$2-5 visibly moves her rank). Field analogs bound the expectation: points-pressure lifted supermarket sales ~6% during the program, and leaderboard gamification lifted sales ~22%. Build: ~2 weeks.

Guardrail: Low if shipped as specced, and the spec's honesty is what saves it: the banner states dollars and queue position are unchanged and only leaderboard points double, so a fan reading exactly how it works sees a happy-hour-for-status promo, not a hidden exchange-rate trick. It never touches the payment screen, which is where all documented tipping resentment lives

UI: Stage view (performer's phone) trigger button; countdown banner on all fan pages and the big screen — Stage view gets a large thumb-safe 'Star Rush' button with a built-in cooldown — max two per night, greyed with 'next rush 10:40' — so rushes stay scarce and the leaderboard's status value never inflates (the deal-proneness guardrail). Fan pages and the big sc Copy: "Banner: "STAR RUSH — 2x Stars for 14:59. Leaderboard only: prices and queue untouched.""

9. Encore Receipt — Every tip mints a personal thank-you from the performer that the fan keeps.

The tip receipt auto-attaches the performer's pre-recorded thank-you clip, tonight's show photo, and a one-tap follow link; the performer can also fire a live shoutout tied to the tip. Receipts persist on the fan's stars profile as a collectible record of nights supported.

- Enclosing an unconditional gift WITH a donation solicitation raised donation frequency 17% (small gift) to 75% (large gift) — but the gift preceded the ask; this does not transfer to a post-payment, tip-conditional gift, so the feature's headline citation is misapplied

Falk, Econometrica, 2007

- Server writing 'thank you' on the check increased tips ~11%; conceptually replicated including a larger-sample Turkish replication that also detected a small personalization boost

Rind & Bordia, Journal of Applied Social Psychology, 1995 (Turkish replication reported at scienceofmoney.org)

Expected impact: Expect a modest, real lift on tipping — single digits to high teens percent on tip amount/frequency at the show, anchored to the 11-18% lifts from the thank-you/gift-at-payment field experiments, NOT the misquoted 75% from Falk. The most defensible channels: (a) the live shoutout as immediate public gratitude/recognition, which both the gratitude meta-analysis (direct-reciprocity moderator) and streaming-tipping prac · Build: ~3 weeks.

Guardrail: Low if built as specified, with two named failure modes. (1) The receipt must remain a post-tip surprise

UI: Tip receipt (post-payment sheet), persisting to the fan's stars profile as a collection — The receipt becomes a collectible card in the performer's theme skin: tonight's show photo as the card face, the performer's 6-second pre-recorded thank-you clip autoplays muted with tap-for-sound, tip amount in gold, date and venue stamped in Manrope small Copy: "Card header: "Mars says thanks — this one's yours to keep.""

10. Encore Alerts — The tip receipt mints a fan the performer owns: one tap to follow, and a plan-making nudge before every next gig.

Every tip receipt ends with a one-tap 'Catch [performer] next time?' follow button (email or web push, no account needed — Supabase row keyed to the fan's contact). When a Pro performer posts their next gig, followers get a notification that asks a concrete plan question: 'Thursday 8pm at The Hideout — think you'll make it?' with Yes/Maybe buttons. The performer's dashboard shows the follow list and RSVP counts; free tier has no fan list at all.

- Plan-making phone prompts (eliciting what time, where coming from, what doing beforehand) raised 2008 turnout +4.1pp overall and +9.1pp in single-eligible-voter households (N=287,228); critically, the self-prediction arm ('do you expect to vote?') had NO significant effect — specificity of the plan, not the yes/no question, is the active ingredient

Nickerson & Rogers, Psychological Science, 2010

- Large-sample field replication of Greenwald's self-prophecy effect (merely asking people to predict whether they'll vote) found no effect on turnout — the bare 'will you make it?' prediction question is the one non-replicated piece of the candidate's design

Smith, Gerber & Orlich, Political Psychology, 2003

Expected impact: The counterfactual for a bar musician is zero contact with last gig's tippers, so the entire follow list is incremental reach. Conservatively: if a Pro performer banks 20-40 follows over a month of gigs (opt-in at peak positive affect post-tip is the best possible capture moment per the active-choice evidence), and reminders shift attendance on the order the Cochrane estimate implies (~10-15% relative lift, here lift · Build: ~4 weeks.

Guardrail: Low, and it survives full disclosure: the fan initiates the follow on their own receipt (no default, no pre-checked box — which is precisely why Cioffi & Garner applies), notifications are exactly what they claim to be, and RSVP counts are performer-facing only, so no public pressure or guilt mechanic touches fans — the guilt-tipping/tipping-resentment backlash literature is no

UI: Tip receipt footer (follow button) + email/web-push notification + 'Your fans' panel on the performer dashboard — The receipt card ends with a single full-width teal button — an active choice, never pre-checked (the active-decision evidence): one tap captures email or web push with no account creation. Gig notifications use the plan-question pattern that actually replicates Copy: "Notification: "Thursday 8pm at The Hideout — think you'll make it? [Yes] [Maybe]" / receipt button: "Catch Mars next time?"

The free / Pro line

Free forever: QR code + performer page + unlimited song requests; Tipping with Stripe Connect + Apple Pay, 100% to the performer, normal payout speed; Full live queue with tip-ordered ranking; Buy-the-band-a-drink mode; Basic profile with default theme + basic tip receipt (amount + text thank-you); Tonight's total at set end; Fan-side experience identical for free and Pro performers in trust-critical respects: exact total always shown, custom amount always available, no dark patterns anywhere on the free/Pro line

Pro: Earnings Insights dashboard; Room-Tuned Presets; Bump Meter; Hype Ticker; Tonight's Fund; Encore Tap; Make It Even; Marquee Request; Star Rush Hour; Encore Receipt; Encore Alerts; Profile themes / Gen-Z skins beyond the default

Pricing verdict

KEEP \$4.99/mo as the monthly sticker — the money on the table is not the monthly digit, it is the missing annual plan and the missing trial. Why \$4.99 holds against \$6.99: (1) left-digit research (Thomas & Morwitz

2005; Strulov-Shlain 2023) confirms sub-\$5 is read as 'four dollars,' and Anderson & Simester's field experiments show 9-endings themselves lift demand ~8%, so the ending is right; (2) the musician's reference prices are brutal — DistroKid Musician is \$24.99/YEAR (~\$2.08/mo) and Linktree Starter is \$5/mo, so \$6.99 prices above the two anchors every gigging musician already knows; (3) \$4.99 preserves the product's own killer frame: Pro costs less than the middle tip chip, so the pitch is literally 'one \$5 tip a month pays for Pro' — at \$6.99 that sentence dies. Where money IS being left: (a) ADD PRO ANNUAL AT \$39 (\$3.25/mo, 'save 35%'), pre-highlighted as the default choice with monthly \$4.99 as its live anchor — gig income is seasonal and monthly subs will churn in dry months; annual converts 12 cancel-decisions a year into one, and subscription-industry data (RevenueCat State of Subscription Apps) consistently shows annual plans realize roughly double the LTV of monthly at sub-\$10 price points; (b) ADD A ONE-GIG TRIAL ('Run Pro free at your next gig') — free-trial research shows in-trial usage is what predicts conversion, and one real night with Bump Meter and the Hype Ticker is worth more than any feature list; (c) DEFER \$6.99 until the LA open-mic cohort yields a documented earnings lift (e.g., 'Pro rooms tip +\$18/night median') — then raise for new subscribers only and grandfather existing ones, which dual-entitlement fairness research (Kahneman, Knetsch & Thaler 1986) shows is the increase people judge fair. Do NOT add a fake third tier as a decoy: asymmetric dominance fails with real products (Frederick, Lee & Baskin 2014); the Free / \$39-annual (highlighted) / \$4.99-monthly menu gets its lift from anchoring and the robust compromise effect instead. Sanity math: at HBR-typical 2-5% freemium conversion this needs thousands of free performers before Pro pays real money — which is exactly why the free tier must stay a complete gig tool (the k-factor engine) and Pro must sell only 'earn more,' never 'un-cripple.'

Upgrade moments (when the paywall appears)

- THE FIRST \$50 NIGHT (primary): the post-set recap shows 'You made \$63 tonight' beside one locked panel — 'Pro shows you which songs, hours, and chip sizes did it' — with checkout copy 'Pro = one \$5 tip a month.' This times the ask at the peak-end emotional high AND pays it from tonight's windfall, the mental account people spend most freely from; never show fake blurred numbers, only genuinely computed ones behind the lock.
- THE DOUBLE-TIP NIGHT (truthful, data-triggered): when the tips table shows the same fan tipped twice in one night, the recap says '2 fans came back to tip you again tonight — Encore Tap makes the second tip one tap.' The performer's own data makes the case; no hypotheticals.
- THE THIRD GIG IN 30 DAYS (habit formed): cumulative recap — '41 people tipped you this month, and you can't reach a single one of them. Encore Alerts turns tonight's tippers into a list you own.' Loss-framed but factually true, and it sells the retention paradigm itself.
- THE BUMP WAR (event-triggered): a night with 3+ competitive bumps triggers 'A bump war broke out over Valerie tonight — Bump Meter shows every fan exactly how few dollars close the gap.'
- THE ONE-GIG TRIAL AS THE CLOSER on any of the above: 'Run Pro free at your next gig' — opt-in, scoped to one night, card not required. The performer feels the lift live, and switching back is now a visible loss (trial endowment); in-trial usage is the published predictor of conversion.

The sustainability answer, verbatim: "LiveQueue makes money from performers, never from fans: musicians who want extra earning tools pay a flat \$4.99 a month, and 100% of every tip goes straight to the performer through Stripe — the money never touches our hands."

Engineering: are we prepared?

Not today — but the gap is about two weeks of focused work, not months, and nothing missing is hard. What is genuinely ready: Stripe is already live (Connect Express money path needs zero changes and must get zero changes — the two-rail billing design guarantees the subscription never brushes tip money); Supabase realtime already carries the queue and tips channels, which means Bump Meter, Hype Ticker, Tonight's Fund and Room Presets are mostly rendering work on existing data; static Netlify hosting is fine because Pro entitlement is a column read, not a compute layer. What is missing today: (1) the entire billing/entitlement layer — no pro columns on artist_settings, no webhook, and critically LiveQueue has never run server-side code, so introducing Netlify Functions with secret management (Stripe secret key, Supabase service-role key) is the real first milestone; (2) per-feature gating conventions (isPro helper, RLS locking pro columns from client writes); (3) three features (Star Rush Hour, Encore Receipt persistence, and the Hype Ticker's skin) depend on the stars/Top Fans fan-page redesign that is still in progress — do not let Pro block on it, sequence those features after it lands; (4) no outbound channel exists for the retention flagship — web push service worker and a free-tier email provider are new infrastructure for Encore Alerts; (5) ops housekeeping: a pricing page, subscription terms in the ToS, Customer Portal configuration, and flipping on Stripe Tax while revenue is near zero. Recommended gate: ship billing + Make It Even + Room-Tuned Presets + Bump Meter (cumulative 8 weeks) as the sellable v1 — that bundle demonstrably raises a single night's take, which is the pitch that converts at the LA open mic beachhead; start selling founding-member Pro there immediately and begin charging when gate 1 ships, then let the remaining 18 weeks of features roll out to paying subscribers as visible momentum.

Billing architecture: TWO STRIPE PRODUCTS, TWO DISJOINT MONEY GRAPHS — the architecture is clean and confirmed. (1) Tips: fan -> PaymentIntent created as a DIRECT CHARGE on the performer's Stripe Connect Express account (acct_...), application_fee_amount = 0. Funds never enter LiveQueue's platform balance; Stripe fees are the performer's; the trust moat is structural, not policy. Nothing about Pro touches this graph. (2) Subscription: the performer additionally becomes a CUSTOMER (cus_...) on LiveQueue's own platform account, with a Stripe Billing subscription (sub_...) to one Price: \$4.99/mo. Same Stripe platform login, zero interaction between the two products. CRITICAL RULE: never implement the fee as a Connect debit/deduction from the connected account's balance — that would take the fee out of tip money and visibly break 'we never touch the money'. The subscription is a normal card-on-file SaaS charge on a s

Full build order totals ~26 nights-and-weekends weeks; the first shippable slice (billing rail + Earnings Insights + two fan-side features) is far smaller.

Demo features (the ones another musician asks about): Star Rush Hour, Tonight's Fund, Hype Ticker